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SUKHBIR BADAL WILL HAVE TO FALL BACK ON A CORE *PANTHIC* AGENDA IF HE HAS TO HAVE ANY CHANCE IN THE AKALI DAL

the present SAD leadership has lost credibility. Elections, bogged down first by a legal mess and then Covid, are pending for over a decade. Sources say the new dates will be out soon; the poll commissioner, Justice Surinder Saron, is almost through with the preparations.

Out of its 190 members, 170 are supposed to be elected every five years—the high priests of the five Sikh *takht*s and 15 nominated scholars make up the rest. In 2011, the SAD had won 157 of those 170, but it will be a do-or-die battle this time. Whoever controls the SGPC is said to have first dibs on being the 'real Akali Dal'. The emergence of AAP is a real factor this time. "Unlike the Congress, which is taboo for most *panthic* leaders (a legacy of 1984), it's a fresh kid on the block," says Ashutosh Kumar, historian and professor at Panjab University. AAP has more than 20 legislators with a *panthic* background—Kumar feels they can be a vote magnet. The BJP too is inducting *panthic* leaders and may back them for the SGPC polls. Meanwhile, on March 18, the entire Delhi unit of the Akali Dal quit and formed the SAD (Delhi). Badal's unit had 30 members in the 55-seat Delhi Sikh Gurdwara Management Committee. All of them, along with state unit chief Harmeet Singh Kalka, walked away blaming Sukhbir. In fact, on March 24, when Prime Minister Narendra Modi met the capital's Sikh leaders, Kalka was there. The buzz is that the SAD turncoat now in the BJP, Manjinder Singh Sirsa engineered the defection.

For any chance of revival, Sukhbir has to fall back on a core *panthic* agenda. This includes perennials like pushing for the release of Sikh prisoners (mostly ex-militants) languishing in jails across India, riparian rights, including returning to a maximalist stance on the Sutlej-Yamuna Link canal, and reclaiming Chandigarh for Punjab. These are emotive issues that had fed into the insurgency of the 1980s-90s. (Sukhbir may have a curious opening on the SYL issue: AAP, now ruling Punjab, was till now a rival on riparian rights as the party speaking for Delhi!) Tangentially, Sukhbir's stance on the revocation of Article 370 or the Citizenship (Amendment) Act didn't go down well either with his core constituency, which responds well to federal autonomy and minority rights. The upshot of all this, says Sandhu, is that Sukhbir must realise that Punjab needs a regional party—with or without the Badals. "The *panth* will throw up a new leadership," he says. A big fear among experts is that radicals may take over any void that the Badals leave behind. ■